By May 1967, Rusk, who had wanted India to be a supporter, just wanted Delhi to keep away from the issue so that it would not be a spoiler. His frustration was evident in an "edgy" tirade about a birthday greeting from Gandhi to Ho Chi Minh: "Those who pretend to be non-aligned should in fact be non-aligned and stay away from questions on which they are not prepared to take any serious responsibility." He emphasized, "No one is carrying a greater burden in serving one of India's vital interests, namely, in organizing a durable peace in Southeast Asia," and warned, "If she feels that she must slant her 'non-alignment' in favor of the Communist world in order to keep her credentials clear with Moscow, she cannot maintain her credentials with the US."[108]

Pakistan: Pressure or Persuasion?

The damage already done to India's credentials played into the debate in late summer and fall 1966 in the US on the question of whether or not to resume the supply of lethal military equipment to Pakistan. Initially, there had been little support—the Joint Chiefs of Staff had been the exception—for a resumption of such supply to either India or Pakistan.[109] Following Gandhi's statement on Vietnam in July, however, there was a change in the mood in Washington.[110] Rusk's frustration with India was evident in his response favoring a resumption to Pakistan, despite the potential adverse reaction in Delhi. He stated, "I doubt that we should move toward reliance upon India as our sole partner in the subcontinent because I do not believe that India would accept or play that role."[111] And, if the US did not resume supply, Pakistan would turn increasingly to China.[112]

A late July report that the administration was considering a resumption of spare parts supply to Pakistan was met with howls of protest in the Indian parliament.[113] Indian policymakers, on their part, were concerned that the US would make not just their Pakistan problem harder but also their China conundrum more complex. Earlier that summer, senior Indian policymakers had cautioned their American counterparts that resumption of aid to Pakistan would only make India-Pakistan rapprochement—a US objective—harder. Moreover, they had asserted that Pakistan—and not just North Vietnam—was an instrument of Chinese policy.[114]

Like the US, India did not want to see a closer China-Pakistan partnership, but its policymakers did not think a US supply resumption